reinstated. On top of that, the Protestant youth magazine Die Staffette was allowed to reappear after being banned. Predictably though, six months after Honecker's assurances, bands of FDJ youths were targeting young Christians again. On one occasion, twelve FDJ activists roughed up a young nun at Berlin Ostbahnhof, ripping a small silver cross from her coat. Decrying this state-sponsored persecution, the provost of St Marien church recounted a chain of similar incidents and suggested a new meeting with the FDJ. He recalled that:

Honecker did not respond. New incidents against young Christians were reported in Karl-Marx-Stadt, Leipzig, Dresden, Magdeburg and Schwerin. A state youth convention scheduled for 13 June 1954 in Güstrow was not allowed to take place and all efforts to get in touch with Honecker failed. Twelve months after July 1953, we were faced with closed doors.

Reactions in the international press to the treatment of Christians were almost universally condemnatory.

Unsurprisingly, the events of 17 June laid the groundwork for Ulbricht's increased interest in the Ministry of State Security (MfS) – the so-called 'Sword and Shield of the Party'. Its failure to sniff-out dissent in June sealed the fate of Minister Wilhelm Zaisser, who was expelled from the Politburo and the Central Committee and deposed as minister. Commonly known as the 'Stasi', the MfS was set up under the direct guidance of the Soviet Cheka to serve as a secret police, investigative agency and foreign intelligence service. Zaisser was replaced by Ernst Wollweber, a man of unstable temperament and defective judgement, known internationally as a specialist in shipping sabotage. Under Ulbricht's guidance, he worked overtime conducting a wave of arrests against opponents of the regime, as well as putting emphasis into monitoring the population within the GDR, as opposed to operations in West Germany and elsewhere.